

— SPM 381 · CONSUMER BEHAVIOR IN SPORT

Fan Socialization

How strangers become the faithful — and what keeps them that way

ARCADIA UNIVERSITY SPORT MANAGEMENT · WEEK 3 · FALL 2026

— FALL 2026 · WEEK 3

This Week

01

Fan socialization

How people are taught to become fans

02

Psychological Continuum Model

Funk & James — from awareness to allegiance

03

BIRGing & CORFing

How fans manage their identity after a win

04

COFFing & Blasting

How fans protect their identity after a loss

Source — Readings — Textbook p.120–142 & Wann (2001) p.155–208, Table 8.2 · posted under Module 3 ‘Lecture Slide & Readings’

— ANNOUNCEMENT

Current Topic Discussion Paper #1

- ♦ Due Oct 04th, 11:59 pm
- ♦ Instructions are on the course website — see 'Current Topic Discussion Papers' link



— FRAMING THE PROBLEM

Know Your Fans

- ◆ Sport consumers can be categorized by their level of fandom — the degree to which they are (or are not) a fan
- ◆ *It's critical for managers to know whether someone is a fan of their team. Why?*
- ◆ This knowledge shapes the marketing plan, ticket-sales strategy, and management of seating patterns

— A WORKING DEFINITION

Socialization

A process through which people learn the attitudes, values, and actions appropriate to individuals as members of a particular society.

- ◆ Through socialization, we learn the different roles in society and how to live and act within various roles

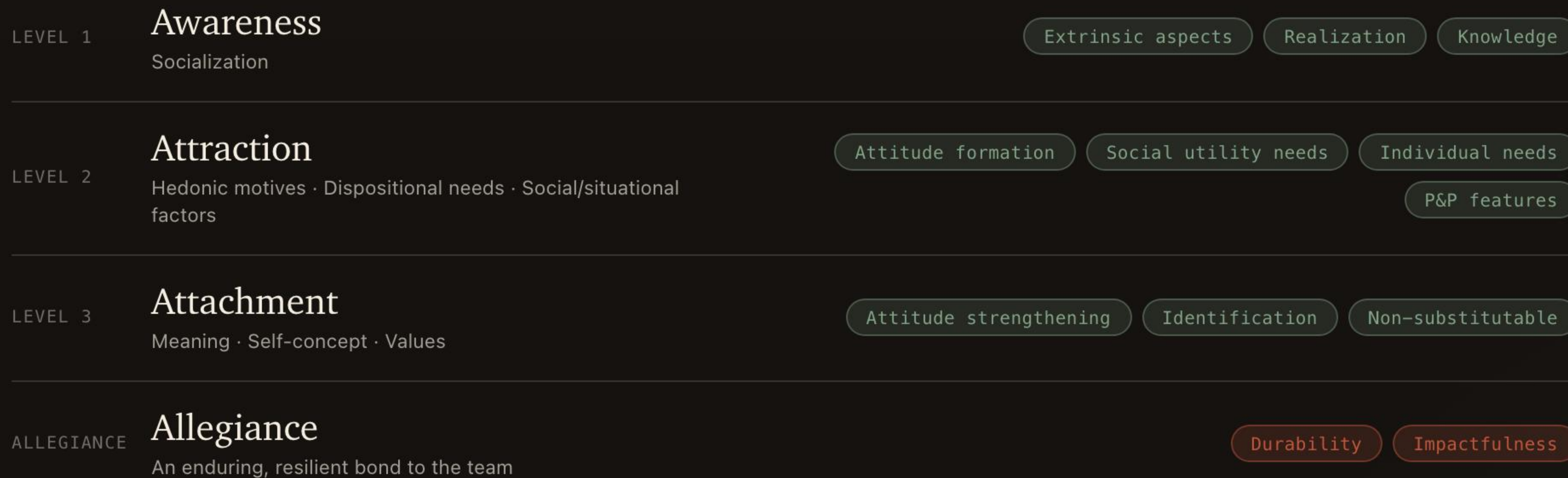
Source – Textbook, p. 122

— APPLYING THE CONCEPT

Fan Socialization

- ◆ We learn and internalize the attitudes, values, knowledge, and behaviors associated with fans of a team
- ◆ *How do people become a fan?*
- ◆ *When can you become a fan of a team?*
- ◆ People can be socialized into being fans at any point during the life span

The Psychological Continuum Model



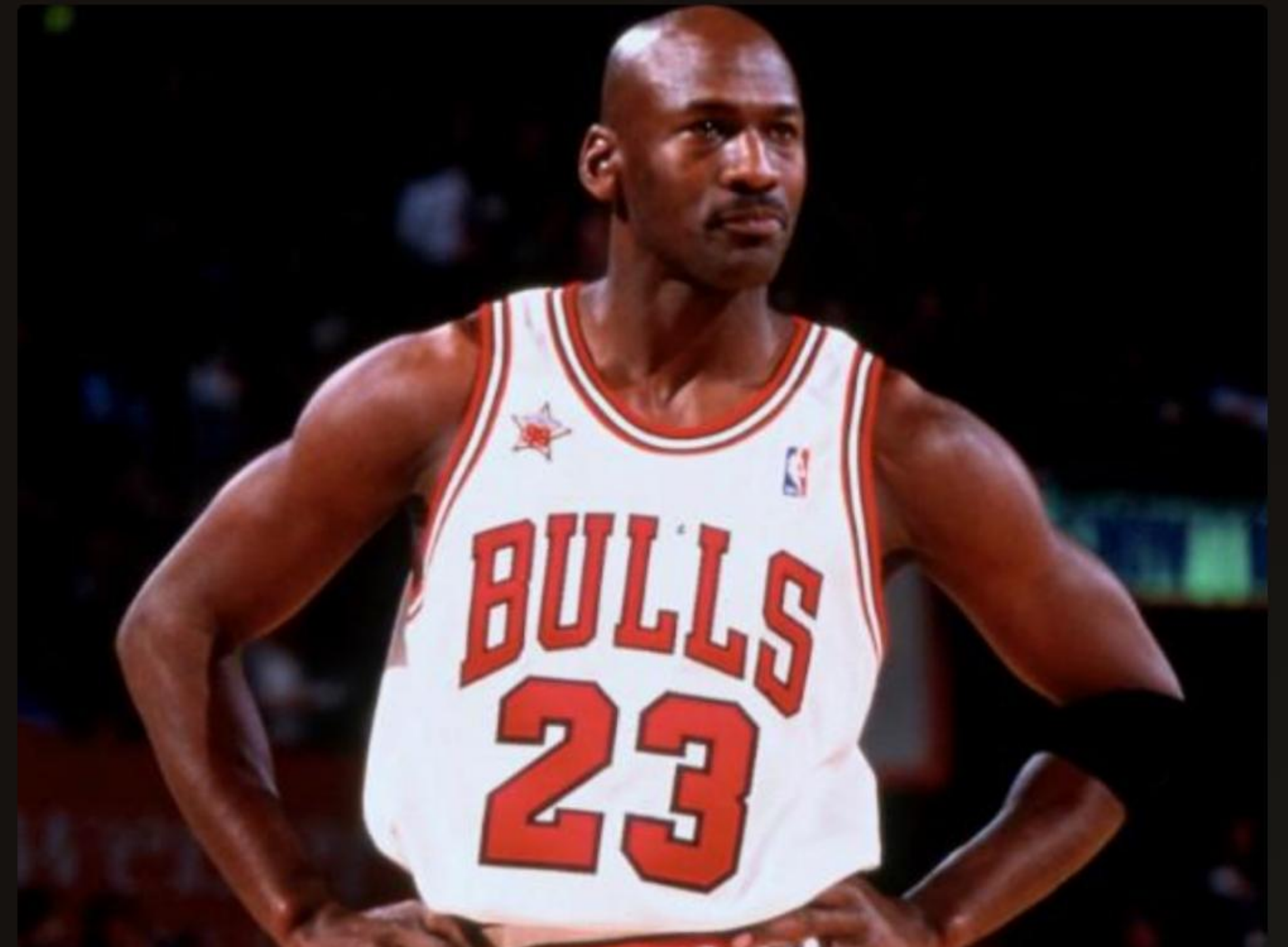
Source — Funk & James (2008), Figure 1 — Revised Psychological Continuum Model

— A PERSONAL CASE

Becoming a Bulls Fan

*MJ was my favorite basketball player,
and the Chicago Bulls were my favorite
NBA team.*

- ◆ I was thinking I have to visit the United Center in Chicago
- ◆ In 2014, I made it — indeed
- ◆ Watch how he played: [youtube.com/watch?v=79MQ4_r7QZM](https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=79MQ4_r7QZM)

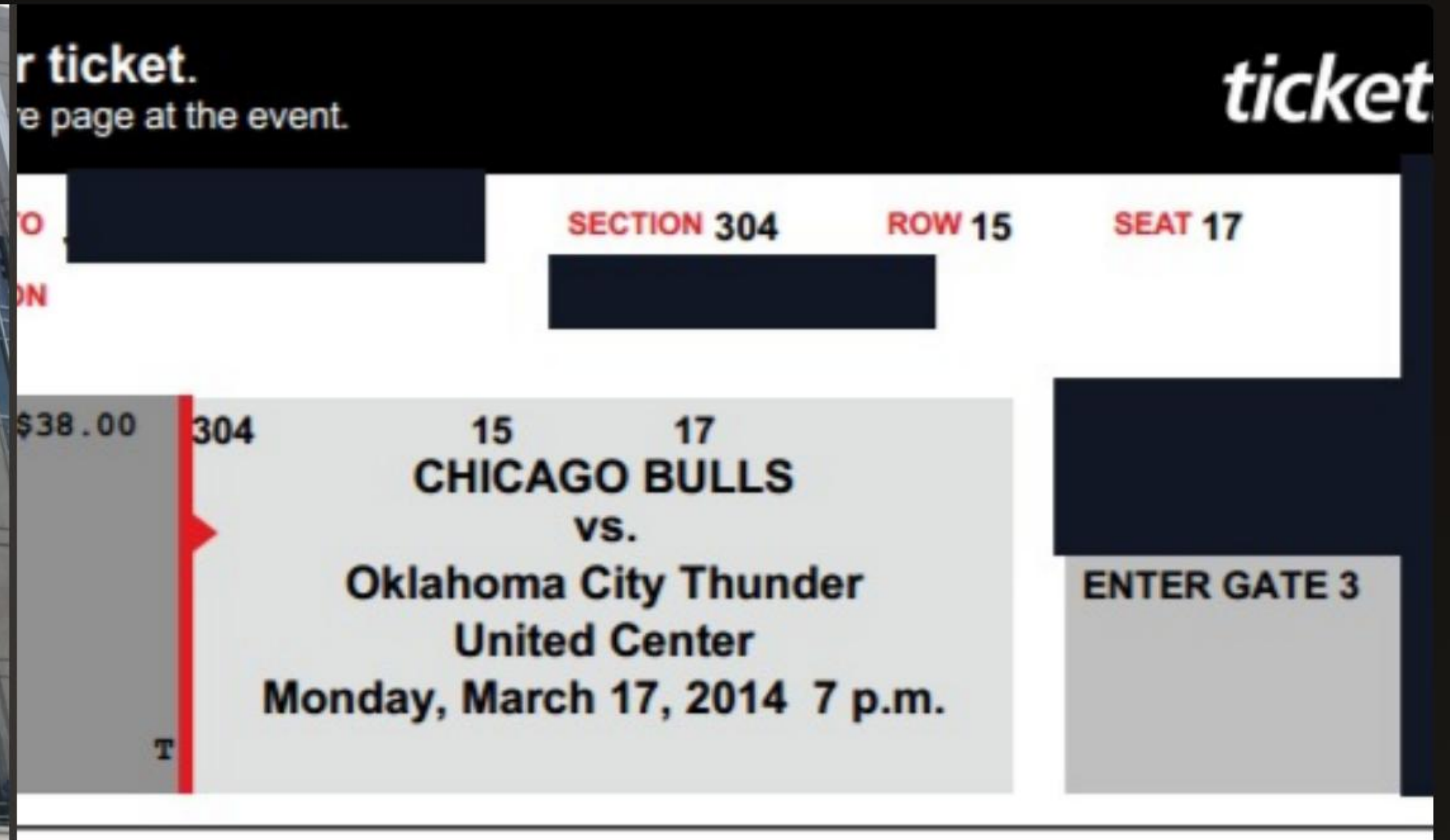


— A PERSONAL CASE, CONT.

United Center, Chicago



Gate 3, United Center



Section 304 · Chicago Bulls vs. Oklahoma City Thunder · Mar 17, 2014



“Was great to be there to experience the Bulls game!!!”

— KOLBE & JAMES (2000)



Fan Socialization, by the Numbers

Kolbe and James conducted interviews, focus groups, and a mail survey with fans of the Cleveland Browns.

38.8%

named "father" as the one person most influential in becoming a team fan

56%

had become true fans of the team prior to age 15 (most between ages 6–15)

- ♦ Fans were asked to identify (1) "the one person who had the most influence on them becoming a Browns fan," and (2) "how important various activities like attending games in person were to them becoming a fan"
- ♦ *What are the implications from this information?*
- ♦ *Any practical implications for sport management professions?*

— KOLBE & JAMES (2000), CONT.

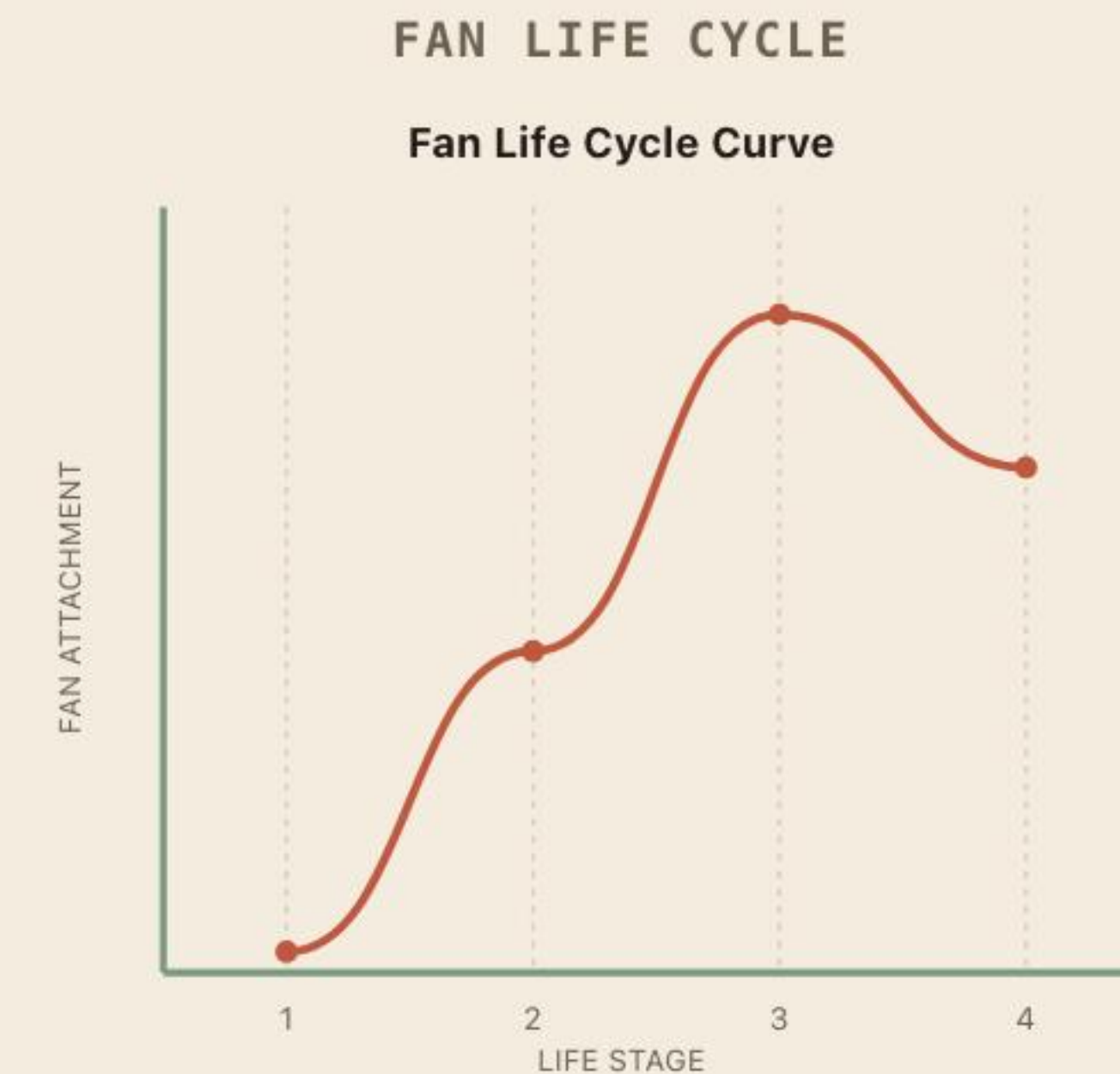
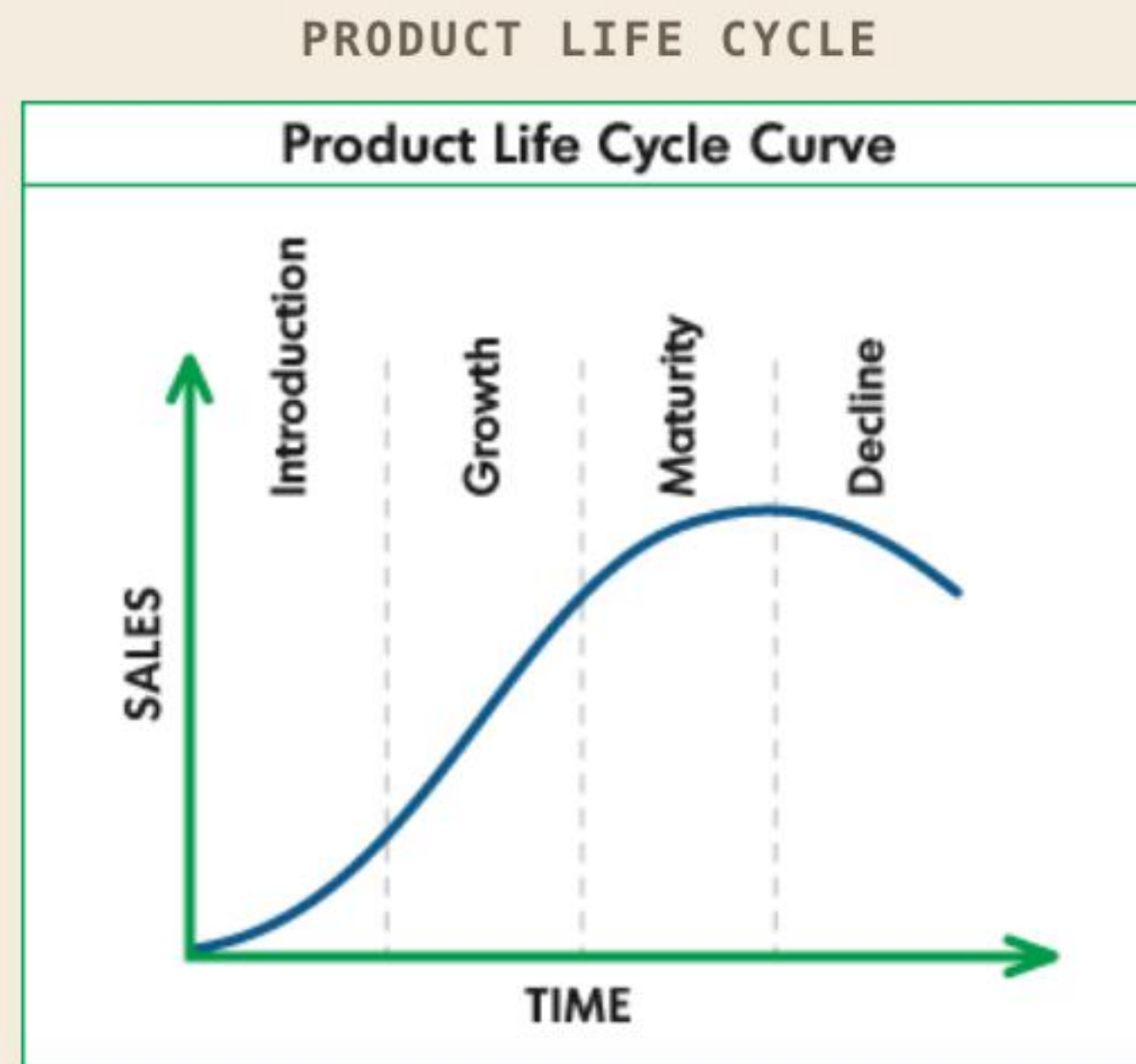
Players, Coaches & the City

- ♦ Adult fans showed a distinct difference from the other groups: players and coaches contributed most to their attachment with a professional football team
- ♦ An emotional connection between the city and the team



Fan Socialization Across the Lifecycle

A lifecycle perspective considers how socializing agents influence fan attachment differently at different points in one's life — much like a product moves through predictable stages of demand.



1 Childhood Birth – pre-adolescence **2 Adolescence** Ages 10–18 **3 Young adult** College years – 20s **4 Older adult** 30 and above

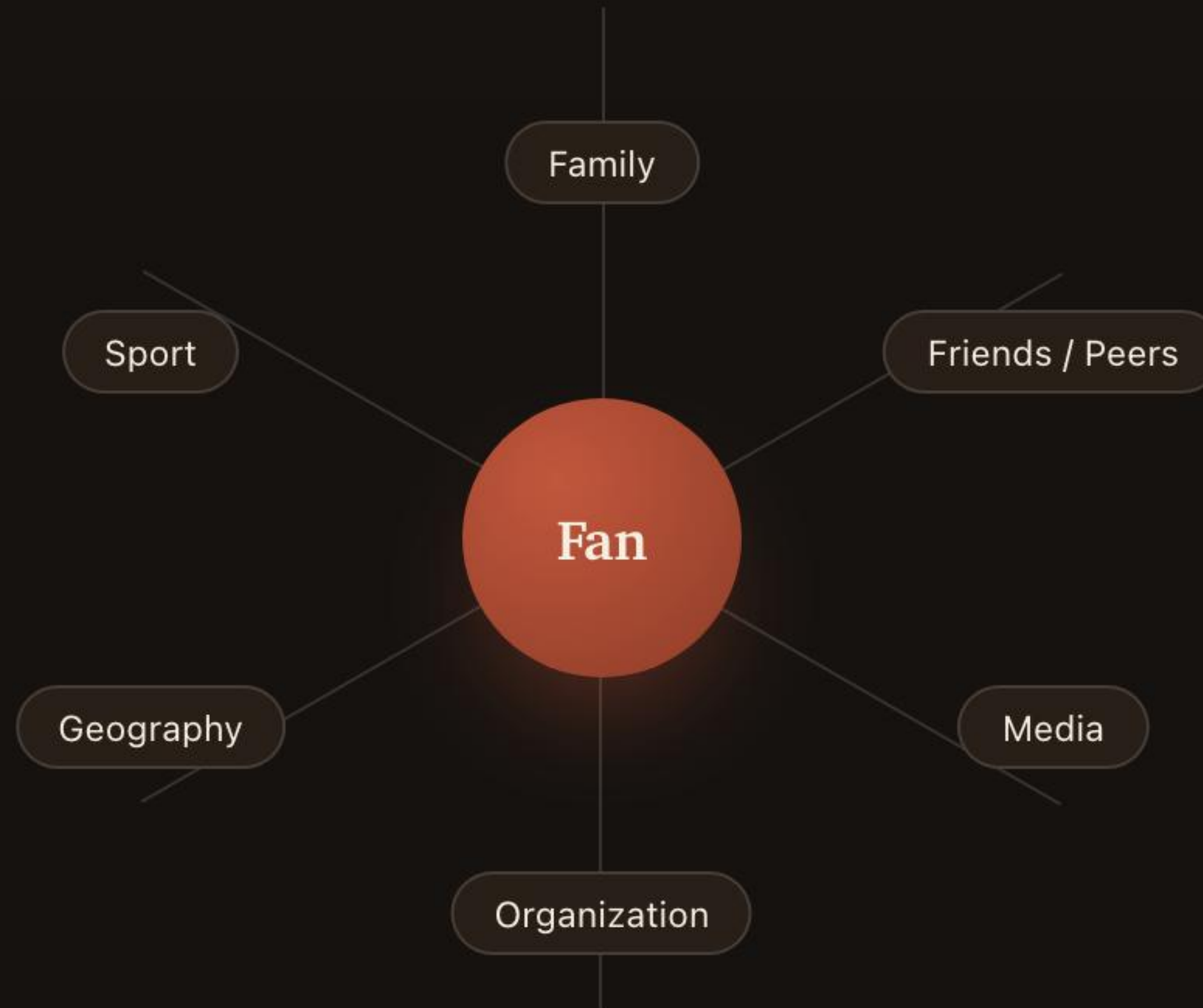
— ACROSS THE LIFECYCLE, CONT.

Six Socializing Agents

- ◆ The four-stage perspective lets us focus on key life stages and explain how various agents influence a person's connection to a team at each stage
- ◆ Most people are socialized into being a fan by six socializing agents, either individually or in combination
- ◆ Various socializing agents have a differential impact at various stages!!!

— WHAT CAUSED YOU TO BECOME A FAN?

Six Socializing Agents



— SECTION 02

Self-Presentational Strategies

How fans react — and adapt their identity — to the outcome of the game

02

— WANN ET AL. (2001)

BIRGing and CORFing

- ♦ One of the most common tactics used by fans to maintain their psychological health is to strategically adjust their associations with their team (Wann et al. 2001).
- ♦ Self-presentational strategies:

AFTER A WIN

BIRGing

BASKING IN REFLECTED GLORY

Increasing one's association with successful teams to enhance psychological health.

COFFing

CUTTING OFF FUTURE FAILURE

Decreasing one's association with a currently successful team to protect one's future psychological health, should the team perform poorly later.

AFTER A LOSS

CORFing

CUTTING OFF REFLECTED FAILURE

Decreasing one's association with an unsuccessful team to protect one's psychological health.

Blasting

OUT-GROUP DEROGATION

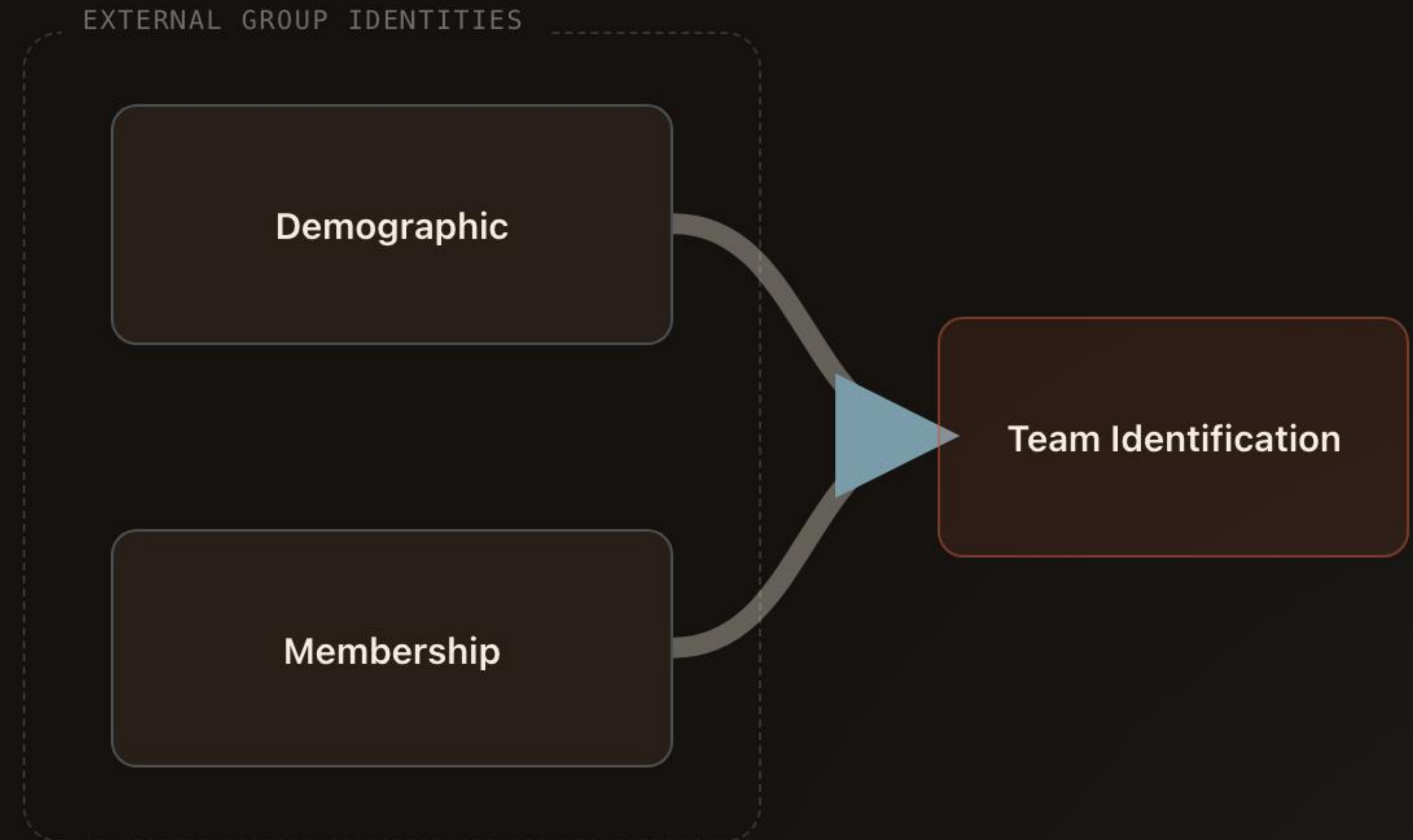
Derogating or attacking the out-group to regain one's psychological health.

Source — Table 8.2; Wann et al. (2011), p. 169 (this week's reading)

The Cialdini Effect



- ◆ Cialdini et al. (1976) conducted college football field studies to demonstrate the BIRG phenomenon
- ◆ Measured students' tendency to wear university-identifying apparel
- ◆ The proportion of students who wore university-identifying apparel increased following a win by the university's football team



— BIRGING, CONT.

“We Won” vs. “They Lost”

- ◆ Telephoned respondents and asked them to describe a recent game involving their university's football team
- ◆ Participants were more likely to use the pronoun “we” to describe a recent win, and “they” to describe a defeat



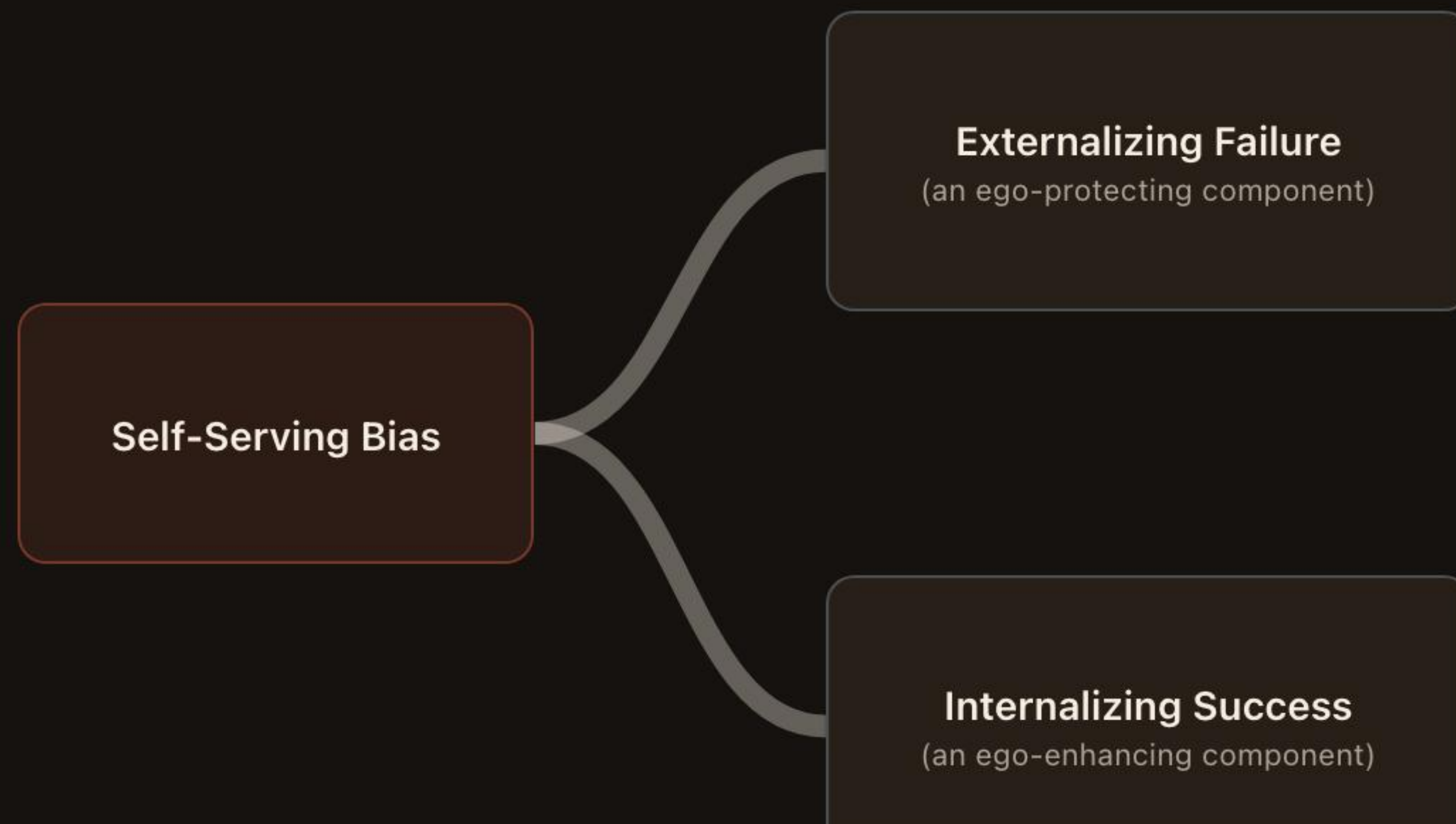
“We Won”



“We are Cardinal Nation”

Blasting

- ♦ CORFing doesn't seem to be an option for truly loyal fans under their favorite team's poor performance (Trail & James, 2015)
- ♦ Fans, to maintain their own self-esteem, derogate or blame the referees, the other team, or even the other team's fans (i.e., the out-group)
- ♦ Why? Fans want to avoid the perception of failure by blaming poor performance on some factor other than the team's actual performance



Two Parallel Continuums

- ◆ CORFing — fans try to cut off reflected failure when a team or player does not do well
- ◆ Not all fans CORF when a team loses; true fans don't CORF
- ◆ Ex) fans not identified with the NY Yankees were much more likely to CORF after the Yankees lost the 2003 World Series to the Florida Marlins (Kwon et al., 2008)
- ◆ BIRGing and CORFing exist on two separate, parallel continuums



Thank you!

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